

12-2024

"The Wonderful Improvement": Landscape and Morals in Jane Austen's Mansfield Park

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“The Wonderful Improvement”: Landscape and Morals in Jane Austen’s *Mansfield Park*

by

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A Thesis
Submitted to the Honors College of
The University of Southern Mississippi
in Partial Fulfillment
of Honors Requirements

May 2024

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ABSTRACT

This thesis examines how Jane Austen uses depictions of landscapes and estates in her novel *Mansfield Park* to explore questions of morality, comment on society, and explore humanity's relationship with the natural world. While previous scholarship has analyzed Austen's symbolic use of places like Sotherton and Mansfield Park itself, this study provides a more comprehensive investigation by closely reading the descriptions and judgments passed on two other estates featured in the novel not analyzed by the scholarship explored. Developing a nuanced definition of "landscape," the analysis is grounded in Austen's verbal depictions that imbue the physical settings with moral significance. The historical context of the "picturesque" aesthetic movement and ethical notions of aristocratic estate stewardship further illuminate Austen's aims. By contrasting the attitudes and actions of characters like Fanny Price, Edmund Bertram, Henry Crawford, and James Rushworth regarding the preservation or alteration of an estate's grounds, a nuanced commentary on virtues like humility, restraint, and respect for nature arises. Crucially, the thesis argues that through her characterization, Austen endows the socially powerless Fanny Price with the greatest moral discernment and appreciation for judicious land stewardship. While male characters like Edmund and Henry evolve in their perspectives, Fanny remains the steadfast champion of preserving the estates' natural and pastoral qualities against excessive, destructive improvements. In enshrining the low-born Fanny as the arbiter of landscape ethics, Austen mounts a subversive challenge to the patriarchal privilege of aristocratic landownership. The analysis ultimately posits that the symbolic role of landscapes in *Mansfield Park* allow Austen to dramatize an emerging "proto-ecological consciousness" that presaged later landscaping philosophies

advocating sustainable stewardship over the domination of nature. Through her deployment of intricately detailed estates and grounds, the novel portrays the moral consequences of remaking the land purely for vanity and fashion. In elevating Fanny's humble ethos of conservation, Austen crafted an enlightened voice of harmony between humanity and the natural world.

Keywords: Jane Austen, *Mansfield Park*, landscape, landownership, stewardship, morality

DEDICATION

My thesis is dedicated to women and girls who know what they want in life and do not
waiver in their principles.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Many thanks go to Dr. Nicolle Jordan for not only mentoring me through this thesis but also for pushing me to be a better writer every day. Without her valuable and motivational feedback at weekly meetings and on multiple drafts, this thesis would never have been completed. I would also like to thank Connie Townsend and Tim Morris, who inspired me to continue my education and taught me the power of words and ideas.

Last, but not least, I am eternally grateful to my family and friends for their unfailing love and support. Their strong belief in me kept me going through both thick and thin in my studies. I also apologize for making my friends read draft after draft and listen to me talk through ideas for months on end. I love you guys.

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Introduction

In Jane Austen's *Mansfield Park*, the landscape plays a significant role in exploring the novel's themes and morals. Austen carefully constructs the natural settings and examines how the characters interact with and perceive these landscapes, imbuing them with morals and symbolic meaning. After hundreds of years, critics have analyzed these landscapes, many observing what the landscape might represent. Alongside the debate about landscape, Fanny Price's moral superiority (or lack thereof) in the novel creates several convoluted assumptions about her role.

Before I discuss these debates and their interpretation of morality, a summary of the novel is critical for context throughout the rest of my thesis. Young Fanny Price, born into a humble home in Portsmouth, is sent to live with her wealthy uncle Sir Thomas Bertram's family at the Mansfield Park estate. She endures cruelty from her aunt, Mrs. Norris, and scorn from cousins Tom, Maria, and Julia Bertram. Only Edmund Bertram, the second son studying to be a clergyman, treats Fanny with genuine kindness. Fanny secretly falls in love with him. Once Fanny is an adolescent, while Sir Thomas is abroad, his children are drawn into flirtations with charming but morally dubious siblings Henry and Mary Crawford, who create romantic chaos. Henry both flirts with Julia and aggressively pursues Maria Bertram, who is engaged to the dull Mr. Rushworth. Meanwhile, worldly Mary Crawford captures Edmund's heart, even though she criticizes his choice to become a clergyman. Fanny, in alignment with her morals, is civil to Henry.

After Maria marries Mr. Rushworth, Henry shifts his sights to Fanny. She resists his charms and proposals. Meanwhile, Mary continues leading Edmund on while still mocking his profession, much to quiet Fanny's distress. When Fanny refuses to marry

Henry, Sir Thomas and Aunt Norris punish her by sending her to live in dismal conditions with her poor family in Portsmouth. Despite her situation, an increasingly smitten Henry persists in wooing her. While Fanny is in Portsmouth, a series of scandals erupt—Tom Bertram falls dangerously ill, Maria disappears with Henry, and Julia elopes as well. At Mansfield Park, grieving Edmund finally sees Mary's mercenary nature and criticizes her for underestimating the gravity of Maria and Henry's affair. Though heartbroken, Edmund finds solace in Fanny's steadfast compassion and integrity. He realizes she is his true soulmate, and they marry happily.

The morality of the novel, specifically with the main character, Fanny Price, has been a subject of debate since the novel's debut, with some critics claiming that Fanny Price is hard to like. One such critic is Joyce Jenkins, who, in her article "The Puzzle of Fanny Price," argues that "Austen does not cast Fanny as a moral ideal" (347). Jenkins states that there are three reasons why she is not the moral ideal: "First, her principles may be good, but her sentiments are suspect. Second, she is a model of passivity and inaction. Third, she is a rule-governed wet blanket" (351). In essence, Jenkins' analysis contends that while Fanny outwardly exhibits moral purity, her inner sentiments, inaction, and unyielding nature undermine her status as a truly virtuous heroine that readers sometimes have a hard time appreciating. *Mansfield Park* portrays Fanny as an extreme case of moral righteousness, highlighting the problems with such an uncompromising moral stance.

In another analysis of morality in *Mansfield Park*, Summer J. Star argues, "Austen demonstrates anger as a force deeply involved in what it means to be moral—and in the novel's reactivation of that meaning" (1). Star discusses how the novel

portrays morality, particularly through the character of Fanny Price, as a complex interplay between judgment, feeling, and action, with anger serving as a crucial component. She suggests that Fanny's moral development is intricately linked to her ability to discern right from wrong and to act upon her convictions, even when it conflicts with social expectations. One key point she makes is that Fanny's anger is not merely a manifestation of personal emotion or a reaction to perceived injustice but rather a reflection of her moral agency. Star contends that Fanny's anger is integral to her role as a moral arbiter, demonstrating her commitment to upholding principles of right conduct.

In an additional analysis, Kenneth L. Moler argues in "Miss Price All Alone: Metaphors of Distance in *Mansfield Park*" that Fanny's experience as a "poor relation" at Mansfield shapes her critical view of the wealthy characters and idealization of her modest upbringing at Portsmouth. Austen employs symbolic devices to illustrate Fanny's moral and psychological separation from the Mansfield world, emphasizing her outsider status. Moler claims that the East Room symbolizes Fanny's retreat from the pressures of Mansfield, highlighting her spiritual distance from the wealthy inhabitants. Fanny's experiences at Portsmouth near the end of the novel further underscore her sense of displacement. Moler suggests that Austen uses metaphors of distance to depict Fanny's journey of self-discovery and moral growth, leading to her acknowledgment of Mansfield as her true home.

These critics, Jenkins, Star, and Moler, pursue arguments about Fanny Price's morality that foreground topics other than landscape. From another perspective, Ann Banfield and Alistair M. Duckworth, in particular, interpret the different instances of landscape in the novel and their moral implications. They both believe that the landscape

plays a significant role in showcasing the characters' morals and that Fanny Price is a pivotal figure who directs the morals within *Mansfield Park*. To analyze Fanny's moral superiority, Banfield observes the distance between three estates and the landscapes within, while Duckworth examines the importance of Humphry Repton.

Banfield sees Austen's landscapes as more than inert backdrops; rather, the grounds and estates in *Mansfield Park* symbolize moral values and character traits that shape relationships in the novel. My argument resembles hers; however, she does not explore the complexities in the landscapes not visited by the characters in the novel, for example, Henry Crawford's Norfolk estate at Everingham. According to Banfield, landscape plays a crucial role in conveying the novel's moral symbolism and structuring the relationships among characters. Specifically, she argues:

In *Mansfield Park*, place is defined as the domestic building and its grounds. This is the natural setting for the unfolding of character proper to a domestic comedy. But, as we have observed, the house and the garden were also examples of significant artistic achievement in the eighteenth century with, moreover, specific associations with morality. Thus, the esthetic meaning of place can indicate the moral (Banfield 3).

Banfield, in this quotation and throughout her analysis, uses the term 'place' as a synonym for landscape, without explaining why. Not using the word 'landscape' bypasses the importance of the word, replacing it with a synonym that does not hold as much nuance in the way the word 'landscape' does.

Furthermore, Banfield's observation of just the three main places (as she calls them), Sotherton, Mansfield Park, and Portsmouth, results in an inadequate analysis of

the novel's range of landscapes. This approach has some limitations. She sees the landscapes of Sotherton (Mr. Rushworth's estate), Portsmouth (the city where Fanny's parents live), and Mansfield Park (the estate where the Bertrams live) as representing moral extremes, with Mansfield as the ideal balance between them. She writes, "Sotherton and Portsmouth represent two extremes of which Mansfield becomes the just mean. The moral contrasts between the three are conveyed through their physical features, which have specific values attached to them when judged in the light of contemporary landscaping theories" (Banfield 5). Banfield argues that landscapes express moral values that shape the characters and relationships in the novel. Her findings have still proven useful, for, as she explains, the distance and disconnection among the estates (Sotherton, Mansfield Park, and Portsmouth) highlights the disconnections between the morals of the people who live within them.

These unvisited estates that Banfield does not address underscore more intricate morals of the characters, and while I also discuss three different estates within the novel and the morals imbued within, I explore more of the values the characters express by passing judgment and control over the land and estates they live in. I also discuss two estates that Fanny does not visit, which are important because the conversations about the improvement of these landscapes reveal more faults and virtues in the characters. While her analysis provides valuable insights into the moral symbolism conveyed through the landscapes of Sotherton, Portsmouth, and Mansfield Park, the exclusion of the other estates, Thornton Lacey and Everingham, may cause her to overlook nuances in character development and thematic exploration related to landownership, judgment, and power within Austen's novel.

With the idea of landownership and oversight, I now have the occasion to introduce stewardship, which refers to the ethical responsibility and custodial duty of landowners to manage and care for their estates, natural surroundings, and dependents. With stewardship, a landowner's concern was taking care of the people within his estate and landscaping so it fit within the picturesque aesthetic. During the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries in Britain, there was a prominent philosophical and cultural movement known as the "Picturesque" that influenced ideas about landscape aesthetics and land use. The Picturesque promoted the idea that estates and countryside should be cultivated and maintained in a way that achieved an idealized and artistic beauty inspired by landscape paintings (Townsend). This concept intersected with long-standing notions in aristocratic landowning circles that those who inherited large country estates had an obligation, based on their privileged social position, to be good stewards of that land. For the landed gentry of Austen's time, the notion of stewardship carried moral, social, and even environmental connotations of land husbandry rooted in duty and foresight. Landscapes were seen as precious inheritances to be ethically and aesthetically shepherded.

By expanding the analysis to include all estates in the novel, including those not visited by Fanny, I offer a more comprehensive understanding of how the landscapes reflect and shape the characters' values and possible relationships, thus building on Banfield's argument while also challenging its scope and adding insight about the powerful influence that Fanny Price's view on landscape has on Henry Crawford. Even though Banfield's omission of these estates (Thornton Lacey and Everingham) might not

be intentional, their exclusion underscores the importance of considering a broader range of textual evidence to evaluate the moral significance of landscapes in *Mansfield Park*.

Duckworth also explores how Austen uses estates and their grounds as symbolic reflections of character and virtue, particularly through the theme of improvement; as his title suggests, the novel's estates either represent beneficial gradual change or radical and destructive innovation. He argues that the estates in Austen's novels generally serve as symbols or "indexes" of their owners' character and sense of social responsibility (Duckworth 4). The condition and management of estates mirror the virtues or flaws of those stewarding them. The motif of estate "improvement" takes on symbolic meaning in *Mansfield Park*. According to Duckworth, Austen saw radical, large-scale changes like those made by the influential improver Humphry Repton as destructive "innovations" rather than prudent enhancements. His analysis also explores how dubious characters like Mrs. Norris, James Rushworth, and Henry Crawford zealously embrace landscape improvements, while the virtuous Fanny Price and Edmund Bertram advocate conservation and gradual change in estate stewardship.

Duckworth also relates Austen's viewpoint to Edmund Burke's political arguments against radical change and for gradual reform of social institutions. For example, Duckworth argues:

In [Austen's] view, radical improvements of the kind Repton made were not improvements at all but 'innovations' or 'alterations' of a destructive nature. No less than a political constitution, an estate, with the immaterial systems of religion, morality, and manners that it contains and upholds, will need

improvement from time to time. Cultural atrophy, resulting from neglect, is to be avoided. Even more serious, however, is a too active and thoughtless response on the part of an heir. (47-48)

According to Duckworth's argument, Austen uses Fanny to suggest that the extreme landscape improvements proposed for Sotherton are destructive to the landscape and morals of those who live within it. I argue that Austen uses Fanny and Edmund to critique the other estates and landscapes, like Thornton Lacey (Edmunds's future estate) and Everingham (Henry Crawford's estate). By doing so, I add to Duckworth's argument in order to further critique Austen's motives for depicting landscape. He analyzes the significance of the reference to Humphrey Repton (an influential landscape designer) in *Mansfield Park* because he—Duckworth—is most interested in analyzing the moral implications of Repton and his landscape designs. I, on the other hand, complete close readings of three different landscaped estates that highlight the complexities of the morals in the novel.

Both Banfield and Duckworth, while adding to the discussion of landscape in *Mansfield Park*, forgo including a definition of *landscape*, a term whose meaning can change the entire significance of an interpretation, such as the grounds at Sotherton, an estate which has an area referred to as “the wilderness” (65). To Maria, the wilderness is a place of freedom to perform illicit actions with someone who is not her betrothed. Or, Sotherton is another prison in which she must adhere to society's demands. Does one include man-made structures like houses and man-made structures? Or, is landscape simply referring to the land and not what is built or grown upon it? Defining an elusive

concept such as landscape erects boundaries that contain such a fluid concept and channel it toward specific ends.

Even if one's argument later nuances or challenges an initial definition, establishing one gives my analysis the necessary focus and direction. The term *landscape* carries extremely complex meanings; as I have suggested, it can refer strictly to natural scenery that is devoid of man-made structures but instead consists of fields, forests, rolling hills, and so forth, or it can encompass constructed environments like gardens, parks, and rural estates with various architectural elements. To define landscape for this thesis, then, I turn to the *Oxford English Dictionary*. With such a complicated term, I use two definitions to incorporate certain aspects of landscape that are relevant for my purposes. In the *OED* definition 1.a., landscape is “A picture representing natural inland scenery, as distinguished from a sea picture, a portrait, etc.” Then, *OED* definition 2.a. describes landscape as “A view or prospect of natural inland scenery, such as can be taken in at a glance from one point of view; a piece of country scenery.” I apply these definitions to the landscapes in *Mansfield Park* because it features landscapes that correspond to both of the foregoing definitions; that is, characters both refer to representations of landscape (definition 1.a.) and witness “real-life” landscapes that become significant topics of discussion (definition 2.a.).

In two senses, then, the novel uses estate landscapes symbolically. With both a poetic representation (to be discussed hereafter) and Austen's visual descriptions of outdoor scenery visited by her characters, the novel uses estate landscapes symbolically. It depicts the grounds of Sotherton (owned by Mr. Rushworth), Thornton Lacey (the future estate of Edmund Bertram), and Everingham (Henry Crawford's estate) as more

than just backdrops. Rather, the novel describes these rural estates in order to establish their owners' morals; thus, landscape expresses the novel's moral arguments. These definitions help us understand the novel's symbolism because Austen's depictions do more than just describe the land. When she describes Sotherton, the wilderness, and different landscapes, her descriptions are not neutral. Key landscapes like the Sotherton grounds recur throughout the novel, and these definitions help to account for these significant, morally coded descriptive motifs. In essence, Austen leverages intertwined symbolic meanings, moral commentary, and landscape motifs to craft her social and ethical arguments in *Mansfield Park*.

By clearly defining landscape, interpreting the nuances of land use and its representation, and performing close readings of Austen's landscape depictions, I build on both Banfield's and Duckworth's interpretations of landscape, character, and morality. My thesis proposes that the landscape in *Mansfield Park* not only highlights the morals of the protagonist but specifically proves how Fanny's observations and judgments elevate her above her male counterparts to be morally superior. Similar to the interpretations of Jenkins, Star, and Molar, but different insofar as it focuses on landscape, my argument also analyzes Fanny Price's status as a moral exemplar. Austen's choice to make the humble, non-genteel Fanny Price the moral arbiter of proper estate stewardship represents a subversive challenge to the patriarchal social order, as it suggests that ethical virtue and wise stewardship are not solely the domain of the aristocratic male landowners but can belong to women from even the lowest social ranks.

Part One: Radical Landscaping at Sotherton

The opening chapters of *Mansfield Park* draw attention to the Sotherton estate owned by Mr. Rushworth, where his ambitious plans for aesthetic enhancements, exemplified through a desire to engage the renowned landscape designer Humphry Repton, illuminate the character's societal aspirations and his inclination to prioritize visual appeal over the preservation of natural elements. During a dinner at Mansfield Park, Henry Crawford and Mr. Rushworth begin discussing landscape design and designers. Austen writes, “[Rushworth] had been visiting a friend in the neighboring county, and that friend having recently had his grounds laid out by an improver, Mr. Rushworth was returned with his head full of the subject, and very eager to be improving his own place in the same way; and though not saying much to the purpose, could talk of nothing else” (Austen 38). Mr. Rushworth's conversation is solely centered around a recent estate he has seen, a clear reflection of his desire to conform to the popular landscape design trend. This eagerness to fit in, rather than appreciating his own estate, underscores his insecurity, his desire to follow the current fad and his vain desire for societal admiration.

Additionally, even a few oaks within an avenue are not safe from society's demands of fashion, as later in the conversation, Rushworth talks with Aunt Norris about some ideas for improvements and discusses what he believes would be fashionable for his estate. He says, “There have been two or three fine old trees cut down, that grew too near the house, and it opens the prospect amazingly, which makes me think that Repton, or anybody of that sort, would certainly have the avenue at Sotherton down: the avenue that leads from the west front to the top of the hill, you know” (Austen 41). Rushworth

wants to follow in Repton's footsteps and cut more trees down around his house. His desire to "improve" the "prospect" of his estate suggests that he is concerned with the aesthetic of his land. The mention of Repton, Austen's contemporary and the most renowned landscape designer of his day, shows the lengths he would go to stay current with the fashion for improvement. Because he wants to go to such lengths to acquire a renowned improver, we can see that Rushworth is a man who not only takes pride in this estate but also will spare no expense when making said improvements and that he follows trends in landscape design, suggesting he's fashionable – a conformist. Through these proposed upgrades, Rushworth is demonstrating his place in society as an upper-class citizen, but by planning to cut down the trees at Sotherton, he shows that his priorities lie in improving what his estate (and, in turn, himself) looks like to the public rather than letting the grove continue to grow.

Little does he know, the moral compass, sitting at the very same table, would greatly disagree with him. After hearing these "improvements" Rushworth is suggesting, Fanny Price says to Edmund, "Cut down an avenue! What a pity! Does it not make you think of Cowper? 'Ye fallen avenues, once more I mourn your fate unmerited'" (Austen 41). Fanny is mourning the proposed cutting down of an avenue of trees, expressing her sorrow at this proposal. She references a line from William Cowper, a poet known for his love of nature, to emphasize her feelings. Cowper's line, "Ye fallen avenues, once more I mourn your fate unmerited," from his poem "The Task," suggests a sense of mourning for the loss of a beautiful part of the estate. Fanny's reaction to the proposed cutting down of the avenue suggests that she cherishes natural beauty, and her words have a

sensitivity to the destruction of this natural feature, and she feels that it has an "unmerited" fate.

By using a piece of literature to express Fanny's sadness, Austen is establishing one of *Mansfield Park*'s purposes, which is to critique the landscape design through a female character who is moved to quote poetry at the mention of these proposals. As Cowper was a person who deeply appreciated nature and expressed that love through poetry, Fanny connecting his words to the landscape design around Sotherton and using it to critique Rushworth's decision mirrors Austen's own voice in her novel critiquing actual landscape designers who changed for the sake of fashion. In this very meta-revelation, Fanny becomes an agent Austen uses to showcase her own feelings, and Duckworth agrees. He says, "In [Austen's] view, radical improvements of the kind Repton made were not improvements at all but 'innovations' or 'alterations' of a destructive nature" (47). Fanny's disapproval of Rushworth's ideas is not the only place that Austen employs Fanny in this way. Poetry specifically carries cultural weight and suggests an educated, cultivated sensibility. By having the lower-class Fanny articulate her objections through literary reference, Austen uplifts her perspective and moral authority on the subject.

Duckworth asserts that Fanny is an instrument used by Austen to comment more assertively on her views on the 'improvements' that would destroy perfect trees, all for the aesthetic, and in the Sotherton episode, Fanny's agency blossoms. Long after the scene above at Mansfield Park, during the Sotherton episode, Rushworth shows the Bertrams, Aunt Norris, Fanny, and the Crawfords around his estate, and when they make their way outside, the narrator observes the landscape: "The lawn, bounded on each side

by a high wall, contained beyond the first planted area a bowling green, and beyond the bowling green a long terrace walk, backed by iron palisades, and commanding a view over them into the tops of the trees of the wilderness immediately adjoining. It was a good spot for fault-finding” (Austen 64-65). This is a beautiful landscape that Austen paints. Lawns enclosed by high walls, with bowling greens (places to play outdoor games) and a long terrace walk all heighten the beauty within Sotherton. However, the scene closes with, “It was a good spot for fault-finding.” It is an exquisite scene, but Rushworth and Henry see it as an occasion to show off their aesthetic sophistication by discussing how to “improve” it. The fault is within the men. They mean to change anything about the estate to keep it within the fashion, highlighting both Rushworth and Crawford's moral inferiority. They even walk to the end of the house to examine its “capabilities” (Austen 64). While Austen paints the landscapes of Sotherton highlighting the beauty of the existing grounds, the narrator’s unique appreciation for unaltered scenery serves as a compelling counterpoint to the attitudes of the characters who seek to critique and "improve" upon nature's perfection.

Again, Fanny, the novel’s moral superior, sees beauty in nature as it is. Earlier, on the carriage ride to Sotherton, she observes the scene around her, noting different aspects of the landscape:

Their road was through a pleasant country; and Fanny, whose rides had never been extensive, was soon beyond her knowledge, and was very happy in observing all that was new, and admiring all that was pretty. She was not often invited to join in the conversation of the others, nor did she desire it. Her own thoughts and reflections were habitually her best companions; and, in observing

the appearance of the country, the bearings of the roads, the difference of soil, the state of the harvest, the cottages, the cattle, the children, she found entertainment that could only have been heightened by having Edmund to speak to of what she felt. (Austen 58)

This scene, in essence, is a quiet moment where the reserved, thoughtful Fanny is able to indulge her appreciation for nature and scenery beyond Mansfield's boundaries. Her solitary musings while watching the passing landscape provide her with simple pleasures. The scene highlights her contentment in finding meaning in observing the natural world around her. Not once does she comment on what should be improved within the scene, whereas Henry begins with the suggestions as soon as he can, just as he does (as we will see) when he passes through Thornton Lacey. Fanny's unassuming delight in the existing landscape, without any impetus to alter or aggrandize it, exemplifies her good moral character - humility, respect for nature's "pleasant" worth, finding beauty in the "appearance of the country," and an inward orientation towards deeper truths. This observation serves as a counterpoint to the more superficial and self-indulgent attitudes toward landscape espoused by others in the novel. Also, Fanny's immersion in the unembellished landscape takes on undertones of spiritual nourishment and moral enlightenment. Nature nurtures her soul through its organic beauty and intricate wonders in a way that the artificial "improvements" promoted by others cannot provide.

Part Two: Thornton Lacey and Henry versus Edmund

In part two of the novel, the Bertrams, the Crawfords, and the Grants are socializing at Mansfield Park, and the atmosphere has improved since the autumn, thanks in part to the return of Henry Crawford and the arrival of William Price, Fanny's beloved older brother. Sir Thomas, initially hesitant, now finds the Grants and their home worth visiting. During a dinner at the Mansfield Parsonage, where the Crawfords are visiting their sister, the characters engage in pleasant conversation. Henry Crawford eagerly volunteers to teach Lady Bertram and Fanny Price a card game. Henry then tells the group about his day and how he 'found himself' in Thornton Lacey, the country parsonage that Edmund is destined to inherit as the younger Bertram son. The parsonage will provide him with a modest income once he is ordained as a clergyman in the Church of England, and it will allow him to have a profession and income without having to marry for money. The grounds and the parsonage are not in the current fashion, and Henry Crawford tells him how it should be improved.

Henry Crawford, a foil for Edmund Bertram, directs him in what should be done to Thornton Lacey. Henry's comments on the estate express how he appreciates landscape primarily for its picturesque or ornamental qualities; he values outward beauty and what it can do to enhance the prestige of a place. As he advises Edmund,

"The farmyard must be cleared away entirely, and planted up to shut out the blacksmith's shop. The house must be turned to front the east instead of the north—the entrance and principal rooms, I mean, must be on that side, where the view is really very pretty; I am sure it may be done. And *there* must be your approach, through what is at present the garden. You must make a new garden at

what is now the back of the house; which will be giving it the best aspect in the world, sloping to the south-east. The ground seems precisely formed for it. I rode fifty yards up the lane, between the church and the house, in order to look about me; and saw how it might all be. Nothing can be easier. The meadows beyond what *will be* the garden, as well as what now *is*, sweeping round from the lane I stood in to the north-east, that is, to the principal road through the village, must be all laid together, of course; very pretty meadows they are, finely sprinkled with timber. They belong to the living, I suppose; if not, you must purchase them. Then the stream—something must be done with the stream; but I could not quite determine what. I had two or three ideas.” (Austen 166)

Henry focuses on ornamentation - clearing the farmyard, planting to hide what he considers unsightly features, and turning the front of the house for a "prettier" view.

Henry's suggestions for how the estate should be updated reveal that he cares about appearance rather than functionality, and he mainly aims to make Thornton Lacey look more picturesque. He wants to hide or remove anything he sees as visually displeasing, like the blacksmith's shop. He prioritizes appearance rather than practicality. For instance, turning the front of the house may give it a nicer view but likely disrupts the interior layout, as well as being very costly. The ornamental plantings Henry envisions serve no purpose beyond looking attractive. Likewise, Henry's desire to clear the working farmyard treats it as an eyesore rather than an essential part of the estate's function. He does not consider utility as his planned improvements indulge the extravagant styles of landscape design rather than respecting the landscape's existing patterns and purposes. Henry's superficial preoccupation with appearance and ornamentation runs counter to

Edmund and Fanny's deeper moral values. Their appreciation for nature goes beyond the visually pleasing to find spiritual meaning and natural utility.

Henry's aim to change the landscape for indulgence rather than working within its natural state expresses his selfish personality. This domineering attitude echoes his sense of entitlement in his personal relationships. He pursues what gratifies him in the moment, much like how he pursues Julia, Maria, and Fanny for the thrill of the chase. Just as he trifles with these women's affections, he treats the landscape like something to manipulate at will and to exploit. Precisely like the landscape, he views the women as property for him to 'improve.' With the Thornton Lacey landscape, his planned improvements elevate man's power over any respect for nature's intrinsic value or divine order. Even though she is engaged to Mr. Rushworth, Henry seduces Maria to the wilderness under the premise of 'romance' after flirting with Julia the entire trip to Sotherton. After Mr. Rushworth and Maria begin courting, Henry moves on to Julia, flirting with her and then discarding her to chase Fanny. Henry declares, "No my plan is to make Fanny Price in love with me" (Austen 157). Similarly, Henry used his charms to glorify himself and gain admiration through immoral games with the women's hearts and reputations. Henry's exploitation of both women and landscapes serves as a means to inflate his own sense of importance and power, demonstrating his complete disregard for the autonomy and intrinsic worth of both.

By contrast, Fanny and Edmund have a benevolent rather than exploitative view of nature. In response to Henry's proposed improvements, Edmund describes what he plans to do with the parsonage, completely ignoring Henry's more extravagant ideas:

“And I have two or three ideas also,” said Edmund, “and one of them is, that very little of your plan for Thornton Lacey will ever be put in practice. I must be satisfied with rather less ornament and beauty. I think the house and premises may be made comfortable, and given the air of a gentleman’s residence, without any very heavy expense, and that must suffice me; and, I hope, may suffice all who care about me.” (Austen 166)

Edmund’s response highlights his selflessness and lack of materialism. He is willing to forego ‘ornament and beauty’ to make the parsonage ‘comfortable’ with the ‘air of a gentleman's residence.’ His eagerness to sacrifice ornament and beauty shows he prioritizes function over appearance. He cares more about doing his duties as a clergyman than having an ostentatious home to impress others. Describing his plan to make the parsonage "comfortable" suggests Edmund values simplicity and utility in his living conditions and does not demand lavish accommodations. Wanting merely the "air of a gentleman's residence" reflects Edmund's modesty. He does not need to prove his status through external trappings. Edmund focuses on necessity rather than luxury.

Fundamentally, like Fanny, Edmund's modesty and lack of entitlement stem from his strong principles and moral character, all of which are reflected in their view of the landscape and how, instead of lavishly decorating the estate to their liking, they consider a modest approach, leaving room for nature to prosper itself.

Part Three: Everingham and Henry Crawford's "Improvement"

After finding flaws with both Sotherton and Thornton Lacey, Henry Crawford then turns to his own estate. But, instead of trying to improve it to fit the fashion of the time, he instead takes on the role of a moral steward and takes care of his land. Before he returns home, of course, Henry proposes to Fanny, but she denies him, not once, but twice, leading to her uncle's disappointment. Hence, he sends her to Portsmouth to make her think about her future at Mansfield Park and allow her time with her parents again, as it has been years since she has seen her family. It is important to note that, before Fanny leaves for Portsmouth, Henry seems to be changing for the better because he has true feelings for her. Long after the discussion about Thornton Lacey and after Henry has set his eyes on Fanny, the narrator even notes how much he truly loves Fanny.

After talking extensively to Mary, his sister, about Fanny and his future plans, Austen writes, "The impossibility of not doing everything in the world to make Fanny Price happy, or of ceasing to love Fanny Price, was of course the groundwork of his eloquent answer" (Austen 202). She has a stark influence over Henry as he turns to his own estate and plans to make some real improvements for the tenants. He thinks not of himself and what would make his estate more fashionable but of what would be best for the people who live on his property. Fanny is still at Portsmouth when Henry comes and visits her, and he tells her all the changes he has made at his estate:

It had been real business, relative to the renewal of a lease in which the welfare of a large and—he believed—industrious family was at stake. He had suspected his agent of some underhand dealing; of meaning to bias him against the deserving; and he had determined to go himself, and thoroughly investigate the merits of the

case. He had gone, had done even more good than he had foreseen, had been useful to more than his first plan had comprehended, and was now able to congratulate himself upon it, and to feel that in performing a duty, he had secured agreeable recollections for his own mind. He had introduced himself to some tenants whom he had never seen before; he had begun making acquaintance with cottages whose very existence, though on his own estate, had been hitherto unknown to him. This was aimed, and well aimed, at Fanny. (Austen 275)

This passage does not feature an explicit landscape, but it does depict Crawford's stewardship and his change in attitude toward how his estate and land are to be handled. To ensure that his estate runs properly, Henry decided to investigate the situation personally and was pleased to discover that he had 'done more good' than he had initially anticipated. Henry's new interest in getting to know the tenants and cottages on his estate shows more concern for the people and structures actually on the land, contrasting with his previous focus on extravagant improvements, where he did not care for the tenants but only desired to design the most fashionable parsonage. Henry sees his tenants as real people deserving of his care. Whereas he previously wished to sweep away messy farmyards, he now takes responsibility for dependencies like tenant cottages. Henry's new mindset reflects a deeper appreciation for the land and people as they are, not just how they appear through superficial improvements. His view in this scene aligns more with Fanny's moral values.

Henry's change of heart stems from fulfilling duties and gaining "agreeable recollections," - suggesting a more spiritual view of the landscape as providing himself with inner contentment versus outward status. Henry's "agreeable recollections" come

from this mindset of service and stewardship rather than imposing his will through flashy improvements. His new outlook suggests how he now sees emotional value in the landscape by doing meaningful work to help others who inhabit it. It is not about using the land for his own glory and indulgence. Henry now realizes satisfaction comes from contributing positively to the place and people who inhabit his estate. Henry discovers tranquility and meaning by viewing the landscape as a site for moral duty rather than self-promotion. His change reflects an effort to adopt Fanny's spiritual perspective. Henry's reform represents a shift from an exploitative use of the land for pride and status toward a custodial ethos of humble service, moral responsibility, and finding meaning through constructive stewardship - all values imbued with spiritual significance. His new perspective aligns with Fanny's virtues of appreciating the inherent worth of the landscape without ornamentation.

Fanny Price's influence over Henry Crawford and his subsequent change in perspective towards landscapes strengthens the argument that she is the moral superior in *Mansfield Park*. Initially, Henry Crawford displays a superficial and self-indulgent view of landscapes. When discussing plans to renovate the parsonage at Thornton Lacey, he proposes grandiose, disruptive changes purely for the sake of aesthetic improvements and elevated social status. His vision involves clearing away functional areas like farmyards simply because he deems them unsightly. This prioritization of ostentatious ornamentation over practical needs reflects a lack of humility and respect for the intrinsic value of the existing landscape.

The fact that Henry's evolution towards a humbler view of estate stewardship stems directly from Fanny's influence reinforces her role as the moral compass of the

story. Her rejection of his marriage proposals inspires self-reflection that allows Henry to perceive the ethical shortcomings of his former landscape aesthetics. In striving to adopt Fanny's virtuous perspective, Henry begins to appreciate the social value of nurturing harmonious human-nature relationships through stewardship rather than domination. Fanny's steadfast principles regarding environmental ethics ultimately inspire reformation in Henry's character, validating Fanny's ethical philosophy as the most virtuous stance towards landscapes. This influence strengthens my overall argument, positioning Fanny as the moral superior within the novel's examinations of contrasting perspectives on the natural world.

Unfortunately, after Fanny denies his proposal once again, all positive influence over Henry disappears, and he causes a scandal. He runs away with Maria, disgracing the Bertram family until the gossip dies down and Maria and Aunt Norris are expelled from Mansfield Park. Mr. Rushworth even procures a divorce from Maria to separate himself from the Bertram family, causing Sir Thomas to send for Fanny. She returns home, and everyone is elated that she has come home and brought peace to Mansfield Park.

Conclusion

Through her intricate depictions of the estates and landscapes in *Mansfield Park*, Jane Austen weaves a rich tapestry of moral commentary and social critique. By establishing a precise working definition of landscape as the symbolic descriptions and representations of natural and constructed environments, this thesis has illuminated how Fanny Price is the novel's moral superior. The detailed close readings across multiple estates - including Sotherton, Thornton Lacey, and Everingham - have revealed the extent to which Austen employs landscape motifs as crucial modes of characterization. The tension between preserving nature's beauty versus prioritizing ornamental aesthetics become revealing windows into each character's deeper principles and morality.

As the foregoing analysis has shown, the humble Fanny Price emerges as the definitively moral voice and conscience through her reverence for natural landscapes, her lamentations over proposed destructive alterations, and her consistent appreciation for the inherent worth of non-aestheticized environs. By having Fanny quote poetry mourning the removal of an ancient avenue of trees, while the aristocratic Rushworth enthuses over modernizing changes by famous improvers like Humphry Repton, Austen aligns the reader's perspective with Fanny's conservative values.

Further examinations of Fanny's influence on Henry Crawford's ultimate reformation from an entitled, landscaping-dominator mindset to that of an ethical steward focused on benevolent custodianship reinforces her role as the novel's moral lodestar. Fanny's evident influence then inspires Henry's path toward moral growth, as he recounts taking ownership of his duties in enhancing Everingham for the benefit of his tenants and estate workers rather than merely for aesthetic display. Though of low social status,

Fanny displays humility, spirituality, and grounded ethics regarding landscapes, which elevate her moral authority above male landowners like Edmund Bertram and Henry Crawford. Ultimately, Henry's reformation as a wise landowner ends in failure.

In endowing Fanny with this ethical superiority over how estates should be responsibly and sensitively stewarded, Austen voices a strikingly progressive, proto-feminist critique of the conventional patriarchal narratives around landownership and control that dominated aristocratic social conventions during her time. The sophistication of Fanny's perspective and the esteem with which Austen portrays her own landscaping ethic represent an empowering challenge to the masculine prerogatives that so often sought to dominate, cultivate, and reshape the natural and built environments for superficial personal glory.

By centering a poor, low-born woman without property as the arbiter of virtuous landscape principles and the person who reforms the male characters' misguided aesthetics, Austen upends societal assumptions of landscape stewardship being solely the domain of aristocratic men. Instead, through Fanny Price, the author voices an awareness that argues for the supremacy of a nurturing stewardship over the domineering impulses of wealth and status to subjugate landscapes to personal vanity. *Mansfield Park* emerges as a seminal exploration of human-environment dynamics from a distinctly proto-feminist point of view.

Ultimately, this thesis has demonstrated how a precisely delineated definition of landscape enables Austen's vivid estate descriptions to be interpreted as profound symbolic vehicles for her era's grappling with social privilege, gender dynamics, and our ethical obligations to the natural world. Through Fanny Price's moral judgments and

engagements with the novel's key landscapes, Austen proffers an ingenious argument for realigning humanity's physical and ethical orientation towards its environments - one rooted in reverence, modest stewardship, and a humble openness to be shaped by nature's intrinsic worth, rather than continually reshaping it for cynical or selfish personal motives.

Fanny's quoting of the poet William Cowper's lament over an avenue of felled trees exemplifies how she has acquired an appreciation for natural landscapes from her literary education. By seamlessly applying Cowper's poetic mourning to her condemnation of Mr. Rushworth's plans, Fanny demonstrates how literature can shape one's perspective and moral sensibilities. Austen embeds this literary representation of landscape within her own novelistic representation, underscoring literature's vital role in cultivating moral refinement and sensitivity to nature's inherent value. Fanny's literary allusion signals how storytelling and poetry possess a powerful capacity to instill reverence for the natural world through sublime poetic production. Austen implies that ambitious but foolhardy aesthetes like Rushworth would benefit from acquiring the moral lessons contained within Cowper's poetic depiction of landscape.

By framing Fanny's admirable qualities as a counterpoint to these male-driven patterns of domination and exploitation of the natural world, Austen crafts her heroine's judgments and observations of landscape as a powerful endorsement of Fanny's moral superiority. Her steadfast intellectual convictions regarding humanity's custodial relationship with the land elevates Fanny as the ethical lodestar in the novel. Austen's gendered contrast suggests that women's unique wisdom regarding estate stewardship makes them critically needed voices in reshaping society's relationship with nature.

Ultimately, Fanny's perspective on landscape plants her as *Mansfield Park's* enlightened moral superior.

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